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Lonergan and Indian Thought

Ivo COELHO *

ABSTRACT: *The article makes a study of the few explicit references to India or the East in Lonergan and goes on to indicate points of resonance between Lonergan and Indian thought. Lonergan is convinced that the structure of human consciousness is transcultural at its core, but he also acknowledges that human consciousness unfolds differently in different cultures. The transcultural element forms the basis of Lonergan's method, and with the variant element it also forms an 'upper blade' or theoretical anticipation with which to approach the 'lower blade' consisting of the data to be studied. The article ends with a brief note on possible applications of the method.*

KEY WORDS: *Apophatism; Brahmanism; Buddhism; Consciousness; Conversion; Creation; Cultural differences; Development; Dialectical method; Differentiation of consciousness; Emergence of logos; Experience; God and World; Indian thought; Intellectual pattern of experience; Language; Lonergan, Bernard; Metaphysics; Method; Philosophy in India; Religion; Sankara; Transcendental method; Transcultural constants; Transculturality.*

RESUMO: *O presente artigo consiste num estudo das poucas referências explícitas à Índia ou ao Oriente que se encontram na obra de Lonergan, procedendo depois a uma indicação dos pontos de ressonância entre Lonergan e o pensamento da Índia. Lonergan está convencido de que a estrutura da consciência humana é basicamente transcultural, embora ele também reconheça que a consciência humana se desenvolve diferentemente nas diferentes culturas. O elemento transcultural constitui a base do método de Lonergan, o qual junto com o elemento variável forma uma espécie de "lâmina superior" ou antecipação teórica com a qual nos podemos aproximar da "lâmina inferior" constituída pelos temas a serem estudados. O artigo termina com uma breve nota acerca das possíveis aplicações do método.*

PALAVRAS-CHAVE: *Apofatismo; Bramanismo; Budismo; Consciência; Constantes transculturais; Conversão; Criação; Desenvolvimento; Deus e Mundo; Diferenças culturais; Diferenciação de consciência; Emergência do logos; Experiência; Filosofia na Índia; Linguagem; Lonergan, Bernard; Metafísica; Método dialéctico; Método transcendental; Método; Padrão intelectual da experiência; Pensamento Indiano; Religião; Sankara; Transculturalidade.*

* Salesiani di Don Bosco (Mumbai, India).

1. India and the East in Lonergan

Explicit references to India or the East are relatively few in the Lonergan corpus, especially in the earlier stages. In the post-*Insight* phase, especially after the 'opening' to world religions, references to India, the East and Buddhism are more frequent, though again always in passing.

1.1. *Insight*: The transculturality of metaphysics

The first substantial reference to the East occurs in the Epilogue of *Insight*. Lonergan raises the question: Can there be more than one true metaphysics?¹ Do not the cultural differences between East and West imply the possibility of different metaphysics?

[I]t is pointed out that a metaphysics in terms of potency, form, and act is indigenous to Mediterranean and Western thought; but is it not to be expected that, once we overcome the parochialism of our outlook and come to understand the mentality of the East, then we shall have to acknowledge a plurality of different yet true and so equivalent metaphysics?²

Lonergan's answer is worth quoting in full:

[T]he argument from the cultural differences of East and West does not seem to touch our position. For while those differences are profound and manifest, they are not differences that lie within the intellectual pattern of experience. A man can unfold his detached, disinterested, unrestricted desire to know by asking and answering questions, and then he operates in the intellectual pattern of experience; again, he can reflect that asking questions can never lead to more than mere answers, that his intellectual desire demands more than mere answers, and then he will endeavor to enter into the mystical pattern of experience. Both procedures have the same origin and both have the same ultimate goal. Both yield their different and basically equivalent accounts of ultimate reality. But both do not yield a metaphysics in the sense in which metaphysics has been conceived in this work; for metaphysics, as it has been conceived, arises in the intellectual pattern of experience, and when an Easterner inquires and understands, reflects and judges, he performs the same basic operations as a Westerner.³

There are several elements in Lonergan's answer. First, cultural differences are "profound and manifest," but do not lie within the intellectual pattern of experience. In the 1963 course *De methodo theologiae* he notes that such differences are relative rather than absolute, and pertain to the genetic rather than the dialectical, to development rather than to the structure of being human.⁴

¹ Bernard LONERGAN – *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 3, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran. Toronto: Lonergan Research Institute of Regis College and University of Toronto Press, 1992, p. 756. Henceforth to be referred to as INCW.

² INCW, p. 757.

³ INCW, p. 758.

⁴ Cf. the 1963 distinction between relative and absolute or transcendental horizons. Relative horizons are related to the earlier 'genetic sequences of viewpoints.' They are rooted in develop-

Second, the intellectual pattern of experience, as well as the unfolding of the pure desire to know, is common to East and West. Lonergan clearly regards his cognitional theory and metaphysics as transcultural, and maintains this position all through his work. Thus he can say in *Method in Theology*:

"[T]ranscendental method... is, in a sense, transcultural. Clearly it is not transcultural inasmuch as it is explicitly formulated. But it is transcultural in the realities to which the formulation refers, for these realities are not the product of any culture but, on the contrary, the principles that produce cultures, preserve them, develop them. Moreover, since it is to these realities we refer when we speak of *homo sapiens*, it follows that these realities are transcultural with respect to all truly human cultures."⁵

Third, metaphysics, in Lonergan's sense of the term, arises only within the intellectual pattern of experience. When one is not operating within the intellectual pattern of experience, one easily mistakes things for 'bodies,' etc. The attainment of metaphysics presupposes the attainment of a critical position, which is the ability to distinguish between things and 'bodies' and also between the different patterns of experience, together with the refusal to commit oneself intellectually unless one is operating within the intellectual pattern of experience.⁶ Failure to reach the full critical position "accounts for the endless variety of philosophic positions".⁷

Fourth, since the intellectual pattern and the unfolding of the pure desire to know is common to East and West, a metaphysics in terms of potency, form and act will be equally valid for East and West.

Fifth, cultural differences between East and West lie in the mystical pattern of experience, or, more precisely, in the religious or transcendent differentiation of consciousness. In a 1963 article Lonergan says this rather clearly: "Where the Greeks differentiated consciousness by distinguishing the practical and the theoretic life, there is a differentiation of consciousness at the base of Indian culture, but it seems to be the differentiation effected by distinguishing

ment, and result more from external factors than from inner conditions. Thus psychological development is a result of education; social development is the result of society; and cultural development is affected principally by the age in which one lives. Transcendental or absolute horizons, instead, are related to the earlier dialectical sequences of viewpoints; they are rooted in conversion; and conversion has external conditions, but is deliberate, free, responsible, existential choice, and so is principally in and by the individual. Relative horizons do not negate the existence of other horizons, but transcendental horizons introduce absolute oppositions: what lies beyond them does not exist for the individual, has no value, cannot be known. Bernard LONERGAN – *De methodo theologiae*, handwritten notes for the course given at the Gregorian University, Spring semester 1963. LRI Archives Batch v.11, items p, r. Cf. Ivo COELHO – *Hermeneutics and Method*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2001, p. 128.

⁵ Bernard LONERGAN – *Method in Theology*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990, p. 282, cf. 283. Henceforth to be referred to as MT.

⁶ INCW, p. 293.

⁷ INCW, p. 293.

common sense, practical living, on the one hand, and mystical contemplation, on the other.”⁸ If the West has given rise to metaphysics, the East has concentrated on mystery. The primary locus in *Insight* for the interpretation of this statement is the discussion of metaphysics, mystery and myth in chapter 17. If mystery is the symbolic expression of the positions, and myth the symbolic expression of the counterpositions, metaphysics is the explanatory expression of the positions. This casts light on what Lonergan is saying on p. 758: “Both procedures have the same origin and both have the same ultimate goal. Both yield their different and basically equivalent accounts of ultimate reality. But both do not yield a metaphysics...” The first procedure yields a metaphysics, the second a symbolic account of transcendence.

Sixth, the mystical differentiation of consciousness falls, therefore, within a descriptive rather than an explanatory viewpoint. Soon after the completion of *Insight*, in 1954, Lonergan is able to say, in a Christian context: “The viewpoint of theology has to do with the order of the universe, which is a manifold of unities developing in relation to one another and to God, whereas the viewpoint of religious experience involves the same relations as lived in a development from elementary intersubjectivity to intersubjectivity in Christ on the sensitive as well as intellectual levels.”⁹ The viewpoint of theology is explanatory, whereas the viewpoint of religious experience is descriptive. Theology deals with, or should deal with, explanatory conjugates, while religious experience is a question of experiential conjugates.

Seventh, the fact that cultural differences belong to the descriptive viewpoint sheds light on Lonergan’s constantly reiterated demand for a shift from occult entities such as the Hebrew and Greek mind to properly scientific categories. He calls this, in fact, a move from description to explanation.¹⁰

Eighth, metaphysics will include cultural differences in a secondary way, for it primarily regards being as explained, but secondarily it includes being as described.¹¹

1.2. *Understanding and Being* (1958): Transcultural Constants and Cultural Differences

Though stating in 1953 that the cultural differences between East and West do not lie within the intellectual pattern, Lonergan has said that they are

⁸ Bernard LONERGAN – “The Analogy of Meaning.” In: IDEM – *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1958-1964*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 6, ed. R. C. Croken, F. E. Crowe and R. M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1996, p. 201.

⁹ Bernard LONERGAN, letter to Crowe, 1954, in: *Lonergan Studies Newsletter*. 14 (1993) p. 8.

¹⁰ MT, p. 172.

¹¹ INCW, p. 419.

nonetheless profound. What exactly might that mean? He sheds some light on the matter when responding to questions in 1958, suggesting that one significant element in the cultural differences between East and West is the influence of Greek science and philosophy in the Western tradition. "There came to the Western world through the Greeks a cultural development, not merely a development within certain intellectual sciences that were apart from the culture, but an influence upon the whole culture, that is not to be found in the same way in these other countries."¹²

What, according to Lonergan, would this cultural development involve? What has been the significant contribution of Greek science and philosophy to Western culture? He is obviously hinting at the differentiation between common sense and theory, between experiencing and understanding, and eventually between understanding and judgment. This seems to be the point he makes when he narrates, in the response mentioned above, the story about a missionary working in a small Japanese village, "who spent six years convincing the bonze in the village of the principle of contradiction. When he got him to admit that – in other words, that the difference between religions was not the same as the different routes up Mount Fujiyama... – when he got the bonze to think in terms of what is true and what is not true, when that point was made and he got him convinced of the relevance of the principle of contradiction in the field of religion, then the bonze and all the village became Christians. That principle was the fundamental point."¹³

We seem to be back again at the intellectual pattern of experience and the unfolding of the pure desire to know. However, we have to pick our way carefully here. Lonergan seems to be hinting that consciousness did not develop in the East in the same way as it did in the West, and that therefore, for example, the principle of contradiction does not hold the same weight in the East as it does in the West. This does not mean that he goes back on what he held in *Insight*. While the *development* may not be the same, and consequently cultural sensitivities differ, the *transcultural constants* remain. Indeed, as he says in *Method in Theology*, the transcultural constants are the sources of all cultural developments.¹⁴

The same nuanced position is represented in another repeated remark in Lonergan's conversations. He says he once asked an Indian Jesuit doing theology in Rome whether the theology he was learning was of any use to people in India. The Jesuit is reported to have replied: "our mathematicians know Quantum Mechanics just as well as people in the West, and we can learn this

¹² Bernard LONERGAN – *Understanding and Being: The Halifax Lectures on Insight*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 5, revised and augmented by F. E. Crowe with the collaboration of E. A. Morelli et al. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990, p. 301.

¹³ Bernard LONERGAN – *Understanding and Being*, op. cit., p. 301.

¹⁴ MT, p. 282.

stuff too.”¹⁵ Lonergan, however, goes on to make an interesting qualification: that Indians with a particular education can learn from the West, but not the masses. He gives the example of the African-Americans in the United States: while a few make it to the upper classes, the majority has difficulty integrating and making progress.¹⁶ Transcultural constants, in other words, provide the possibility of people learning across cultures, but cultural differences, or differences in the unfolding of these constants, have the effect of making such learning either easier or more difficult. Thus there is no plurality of metaphysics, but there certainly are different cultural developments.

1.3. *De intellectu et methodo* (1959): Emergence of the Logos and Philosophy in India

In the 1959 course *De intellectu et methodo*, we find a first specific reference to India. The context is a chapter entitled “The Two Modes of Human Thought,” the two modes being the symbolic and the theoretic. In the introduction to the chapter, Lonergan explains that there is a dialectic between these two pure modes, giving rise to a ‘mixed mode.’ The two modes therefore unfold in three steps, the symbolic, the mixed and the theoretic. The mixed mode is discussed under the rubric “The Use of Language,”¹⁷ and it is in this section that the reference to India occurs. The text reads as follows:

The use of language pertains to the symbolic mode of knowing, [insofar] as this mode develops and spreads...

Here we have the origin of logos. This development took place especially in ancient Greece, although not strongly enough to extirpate idolatry... Christianity contributed greatly to this forward development.

In India there occurred a genuine development of reason, hence a genuine philosophy, but the focus was almost entirely on the subject rather than the object (cf. the Upanishads); as a result there was no objectification of the subject as such, which was identified with Atma.

When the development of reason reaches that point when it is no longer directed towards what is traditional in its own community but towards what is true – in other words, when it begins to use the principle of contradiction more explicitly – that is when religious conversions occur.¹⁸

¹⁵ *Caring About Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan*. Transcript of interviews with Lonergan, ed. P. Lambert, C. Tansey and C. Going. Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1982, pp. 173-174.

¹⁶ *Caring About Meaning*, op.cit., pp. 173-174. Cf. also *Method in Theology, Institute at Milltown Park, Dublin, 2-14 August 1971*, transcribed and edited N. Graham, unpublished. Toronto: Lonergan Centre, Regis College, 1985, p. 606.

¹⁷ In MT, the three modes are: the mode of common sense, the mode of theory, and the emergence of empirical science, in that sequence. The Greek discovery of mind marks the transition from the first to the second stage. MT, p. 97.

¹⁸ “Usus linguae pertinet ad modum cognoscendi symbolicum, quatenus hunc modum et evoluit et extendit... / Sic oritur logos. Haec evolutio praesertim facta est in Graecia, tamen non

A number of questions arise: What does language have to do with the emergence of logos? In what does this emergence of logos / reason / philosophy consist? And what are the limitations of this emergence in India?

The first question may be answered by taking a look at the rest of the section entitled "The Use of Language."

A name [is] something definite to which images can be attached. A name also summons up again a past intersubjective experience, so that the name itself can stand for the actual experience. A name renders possible the free exercise of the imagination... A name is not only the term of recognition but is also something sensible, a phantasm from which the intellect can proceed to further acts...¹⁹

The emergence of logos, we might surmise, is made possible by the objectification of subjective or intersubjective experience. *Method in Theology* speaks, in fact, of "a rising tide of linguistic feed-back" that makes possible the emergence of mind or the theoretic stage.²⁰

The second question also receives an answer from the same section, which notes how learning one's mother tongue involves that organization of one's world that is named common sense; how the first collectivist civilizations evolved according to this mode; and how the emergence of philosophy – not only in Greece and India but also in China, Persia, and Israel – is linked to the more personal turn of thought that emerged as a consequence of great disparities in the bosom of these civilizations:

To learn one's mother tongue... means to carry out some organization of one's consciousness, subjects, objects, mind, and world. Each one lives in his own world..., which is part of the universe that lies within one's own horizon. Common intelligence is precisely that which operates within a determinate horizon.²¹

gradu efficaci ad destruendam idololatriam... Christianismus multum iuvavit evolutionem perficiendam. / In India habita est vera evolutio rationis, unde vera philosophia, at defuit tensio ad obiectum et fere tota ad subiectum directa est (cfr. Upanishad), unde defuit obiectivatio subiecti qua talis, quod cum Atma identificatum est. / Quando evolutio rationalis pervenit ad directionem non amplius versus id quod est traditionale in propria communitate, sed versus id quod est verum, id est quando magis explicite principium contradictionis incipit adheberi, fiunt conversiones religiosae." B. LONERGAN – *De intellectu et methodo*, student notes from the course given at the Gregorian University, Rome, Spring semester 1959, 34. I use the translation by M. Shields.

¹⁹ "Nomen dicit centrum istius affirmationis, quid determinatum ubi figi possunt et imagines. Per nomen etiam iterum evocatur transcacta experientia inter-subiectiva, unde nomen potest valere pro actuali experientia. Nomen praebet possibilitatem libere imaginandi, evocat sentimenta et imagines... Nomen non est tantum terminus agnitionis, sed est quid sensibile, phantasma quoddam ex quo intellectus ad ulteriores actus procedere potest." LONERGAN – *De intellectu et methodo* (1959), p. 34.

²⁰ MT, p. 97.

²¹ "Unde pro homine linguam addiscere maternam significat quamdam organizationem facere tum conscientiae, tum subiectorum, tum obiectorum, mentis et mundi. Unusquisque vivit in proprio mundo..., qui est illa pars universi iacens intra proprium horizontem. *Intelligentia vulgaris* est praecise illa quae operator intra aliquem horizontem determinatum." LONERGAN – *De intellectu et methodo* (1959), pp. 34-35.

This intelligence is not individualistic but common. So we speak of 'common sense.' ...

It was according to this mode that the first collectivist civilizations evolved, in Egypt, Babylonia, India, China...

In these conditions, great prosperity and great misery stimulated reflection on the human condition and a more personal mode of thought. Thus there took place between 800 and 20 B.C. the development of philosophy in this axial period of history in China, India, and Persia (Zoroastrianism). A more individualistic sort of thinking and speaking appeared with the Hebrew prophets... So also in Greece the first philosophers made their appearance.²²

The third question may now be answered: what were the limitations of the emergence of philosophy in India? Lonergan's answer, I suggest, is twofold.

First, there was no proper objectification of the subject in India: the subject was not properly distinguished and differentiated from the Eternal Subject or Atman. India seems to have remained, then, at the level of the subject as subject, or in the realm of religious experience.²³ This is, of course, very much in line with the 1953 assertion that the East concentrated on the mystical pattern while the West concentrated on the intellectual pattern that led in time to a metaphysics.

Second – and here we go back to the 1958 comment – the East did not have the advantage of Greek science and philosophy. What was this advantage that the West had? Probably the development of what Lonergan calls 'methodical scientific intelligence' or the theoretic mode:

Third Step: Methodical Scientific Intelligence

At this point in time a new mode of thinking and understanding appears. *Husserl* has shown quite well that the Greek philosophers took their terminology from the ancient mode of thinking..., yet gave those words a new meaning which previously they did not have...

The most important figure in bringing about this change in the mode of thinking was Socrates. To him Aristotle attributed *logoi epaktikoi*, inductive or conductive arguments...

...

Thus was anticipated the logical structure in which everything is interconnected and each term has a fixed meaning...²⁴

²² "Haec intelligentia non est individualistica sed communis; ita loquuntur de sensu communi ('common sense')... / Secundum hunc modum evolvuntur primae civilizationes collectivisticae, in Aegypto, Babylonia, India, Sinis... / In his conditionibus, magnae felicitates et magnae miseriae stimulant reflexionem humanam et modum magis personalem cogitandi. Sic habetur ab anno 800 ad 200 a.C. evolutio philosophica secundum axem historicum in Sinis, India, Persia (cfr: Zoroastrismum). Apparatio locutionis et cogitationis magis individualis habetur inter hebraeos apud prophetas... Sic in Graecia apparent primi philosophi." LONERGAN – *De intellectu et methodo* (1959), p. 35.

²³ Cf. LONERGAN, letter to Crowe, 1954. In: *Lonergan Studies Newsletter*. 14 (1993), p. 8.

²⁴ "*Tertius gressus: intelligentia scientifica methodica.* / Tunc oritur novus modus cogitandi et intelligendi. *Husserl* bene ostendit philosophos graecos sumpsisse nomina ex modo cogitandi

In 1959, then, Lonergan (1) admits in India the development of language that makes the emergence of logos possible; (2) acknowledges the emergence of a genuine philosophy in India; (3) observes that the objectification was not complete; and (4) that India did not have the development of a methodical scientific intelligence, with its precise and univocal definition of terms, setting up of a system of interrelated meanings, etc. It would seem then that India did not progress, according to Lonergan, from the mixed mode to the properly theoretical mode. I would note, however, that like Parmenides, both Buddhism and several strains of Vedanta established linguistic argument “as an independent power that could dare to challenge the evidence of the senses”,²⁵ and thus opened the way to the distinction between sense and understanding.

1.4. *De methodo theologiae* (1962): The favoring of interiority in Brahmanism

The 1962 course *De methodo theologiae* is even more specific, insofar as it mentions not India but Brahmanism. Lonergan has been distinguishing antithetical ‘worlds,’ and has been engaged in outlining the different ways in which these oppositions can be handled. One of these is ‘simplification’ or the reduction of one world to another:

[I]n Brahmanism there are oppositions which are, however, reduced to one: the world of the sacred, interior, intelligible is the absolute subject, Atman; nirvana consists in absorption into Atman. The profane, exterior, visible world is Maya, the field of appearances, of karma, of transmigration.²⁶

It would seem that this text confirms what we have been saying, that India did achieve a distinction between sense and intellect, or between the visible and intelligible worlds, but we should not infer too much from a passing illustration. However, we may note that the explanation given here is somewhat different from that of 1959. Firstly, the 1959 ‘modes of meaning’ were diachronic, whereas the 1962 ‘antithetical worlds’ are synchronic. Secondly, the 1959 text spoke of an overwhelming focus on the subject with the result that

antiquo... tamen eis novum sensum tribuendo qui antea simpliciter ignorabatur... / Momentum maximum *Socratis* est in incepta mutatione modi cogitationis. *Aristoteles* tribuit Socrati ‘logoi epaktikoi’ = sermones inductivos vel conductivos... / ... / Sic anticipabatur structura logica in qua omnia connectuntur et singuli termini semper fixi manent....” LONERGAN – *De intellectu et methodo* (1959) pp. 35-36.

²⁵ MT, pp. 91-92.

²⁶ “Simplificata: in Brahmanismo adsunt oppositiones quae tamen ad unam reducuntur: mundus sacer, interior, intelligibilis est subiectum absolutum, Atman, in quo absorptionem, nirvana, optatur; mundus profanus, exterior, aspectabilis est Maya, campus apparentiarum, karmae, metempsychosis.” B. LONERGAN – *De methodo theologiae*, autograph typescript of notes for the course at the Gregorian University, Spring semester 1962, LRI Archives Batch V.1.c, 16. I am using the translation by M. Shields.

the subject was not objectified, whereas the 1962 text speaks of a recognition of two worlds, with a consequent absorption of one into the other. But once again, the focus is on the subject, on interiority, on the Atman; the world of 'objects' loses out:

The inner world, the world of interiority, is that of the subject precisely as subject...

Yet there was no differentiation between the inner and the outer world until the emergence of individualism. Primitive man is collectivist...

But after the breakup of the great empires (in China, India, Mesopotamia, Egypt) the cosmological myth was dispelled and men as individuals had to work... for themselves.²⁷

Setting aside further references to India in Lonergan's writings,²⁸ I go on to draw the following conclusions:

1. Cultural differences between East and West are profound.
2. However, they belong to the sphere of description rather than of explanation, to relative rather than to absolute horizons, to religious and mystical experience rather than to the intellectual pattern of experience.
3. Cultural differences do not imply a different cognitional theory and metaphysics. The cognitional theory and metaphysics outlined in *Insight* are transcultural at root, even though they may need to be transposed in their expression.
4. While cognitional theory and metaphysics are transcultural at root, consciousness develops differently in each culture. If, for example, the theoretical differentiation has not arisen in a culture, people of that culture will, as whole, find it more difficult to understand or master theory. Lonergan implies that Greek science and philosophy did not form a significant part of the development of consciousness in India, that methodical scientific intelligence did not arise in India. He may, of course, be wrong in such a supposition, for there was a rich and flourishing system of logic, as well as an 'Indian scholasticism,' as seen in the *darsanas*, both orthodox and heterodox.
5. Whatever be the worth of Lonergan's passing remarks about India and the East, we could use his cognitional theory to work out stages of meaning for India. These stages of meaning can then serve as a concrete upper blade for investigating the cultural, philosophical and religious history of India.

²⁷ "Mundu interior est subiecti ut subiecti.... / Attamen differentiation inter mundum interiore et exteriorem non habetur donec oritur individualismus. / Scilicet homo primitivus est collectivista.... / At post disrupta magna imperia (in Sinis, in Indis, in Mesopotamia, in Aegypto) tollitur mythus cosmologicus, et homo qua individuus pro se laborare, commercia facere, etc., debuit." Bernard LONERGAN – *De methodo theologiae* (1962) p. 12.

²⁸ E.g. MT 109; Bernard LONERGAN – *A Third Collection*. New York; Mahwah: Paulist, 1985, pp. 20, 67, 114, 163, 217.

2. Resonances between Lonergan and Indian Thought

I list here what I call 'resonances' between Lonergan and Indian thought, or perhaps topics about which we might expect mutual clarification.

2.1. Creation

The Christian topic of 'creation' parallels quite exactly what in Indian thought goes by the name of 'the relationship between the Absolute and the world,' for creation, as Thomas Aquinas has said, falls in the category not of action or of passion but of relation.²⁹ Lonergan is not abundant on the topic of creation, but he does have something to say, drawing mostly on Aquinas and filtering it through his own cognitional theory and metaphysics.³⁰ His proof of God's existence, being a posteriori, is certainly relevant. He is also quite clear on the topic of 'extrinsic denomination,'³¹ and according to Richard De Smet at least, extrinsic denomination is Aquinas' way of talking about what Sankara calls *upadhis*.³² The relationship between God and the world is non-reciprocal, asymmetrical; the world is dependent on God, but God is not dependent on the world. Lonergan and Sankara might make common cause against other Indian theories of creation such as the Samkhya and the Vaisheshika, and also perhaps against Buddhist doctrines such as the Vijñānavāda and the Sunyavāda, for Lonergan would surely agree wholeheartedly with Sankara that there is only one ultimate cause, that this cause is of the nature of consciousness, that it is eternal, infinite and non-dual. He would also agree with the Upanisads and with Sankara that being does not increase upon creation of the world. God plus world are not two, though they cannot be regarded as one either: *purnam adah, purnam idam / purnat purnam udacyate / purnasya purnam-adaya / purnam-eva vasisyate*.³³ The relationship of the world with God is therefore best described in the term *a-dvaita*, non-dualism. In this context, Lonergan's reflections on the notion of being and the idea of being deserve closer study.³⁴ The trickiness in the relationship between God and world haunts not only Indian thought but also Western thought, Heidegger and Lonergan being some of the more recent witnesses to it.

²⁹ Properly speaking neither a motion nor a change, the act of creation is located not in the category of action or passion but in that of relation. THOMAS AQUINAS – *de Potentia* 3.3.

³⁰ INCW, pp. 686, 674-680.

³¹ INCW, p. 530.

³² RICHARD DE SMET – "Sankara's Non-dualism (Advaita-vada)." In: R. DE SMET and J. NEUNER (eds.) – *Religious Hinduism*. 4th ed. Mumbai: St Pauls, 1997, p. 90; "Forward Steps in Sankara Research." In: *Darshana International*. 26/3 (1987), p. 39.

³³ "That is full; this is full / From the full, the full arises. / Taking the full from the full, / The full itself remains." *Isa Upanisad* 1.

³⁴ Cf. INCW, pp. 667-671.

2.2. Person

Richard De Smet has done much to clarify the notion of the person as it arose in the West and especially within Christian thinking.³⁵ No less a thinker than T. M. P. Mahadevan is reported to have admitted that the Absolute can only be regarded as super-personal, not as impersonal.³⁶ Lonergan, with his extensive Latin treatises *De verbo incarnato* and *De Deo trino*, has much to say on the 'person,' a topic to which he returned sporadically after completing *Method in Theology*, as may be seen, for example, in "Christology Today" in *A Third Collection*.³⁷

2.3. Consciousness

Indian thought, in both its Brahmanic and Buddhist manifestations, is full of reflections on consciousness. Lonergan, on the other hand, has important distinctions to make between consciousness-perception and consciousness-experience.³⁸ This again would be a fruitful area of comparative study and mutual clarification. It is possible that, by use of Lonergan's method, we recover useful and transculturally valid categories from within the Indian tradition.

2.4. The apophatic and the kataphatic

The apophatic and the kataphatic is another extremely fruitful area of comparison between Lonergan and Indian thought. Very important currents of Indian thought, such as the Madhyamika and the Vedanta, tend towards an ultimate apophatism. Added to this is the contemporary prestige enjoyed by Buddhism and by Vedanta, aided not a little by their congeniality with current New Age thinking. Whatever be the finer points and the proper interpretation of Buddhism and Advaita, it cannot be denied that in practice both

³⁵ Cf. Richard DE SMET – "Persona, Anima, Atman." In: *The Philosophical Quarterly*. 30/4 (1958), pp. 251-250; "The Aristotelian-Thomist Conception of Man," In: *Indian Philosophical Quarterly*. 2/4 (1975), pp. 307-318; "The Discovery of the Person." In: *Indian Philosophical Quarterly*. 4/1 (1976), pp. 1-9; "The Loss of the Person." In: *Indian Philosophical Quarterly*. 4/1 (1976), pp. 10-23; "The Rediscovery of the Person." In: *Indian Philosophical Quarterly*. 4/3 (1977), pp. 413-426; "The Concept of Man in Thomism and Neo-Thomism." In: *Indian Theological Studies*. 26 (1989), pp. 336-372.

³⁶ Cf. B. MALKOVSKY – "Life and Work of Richard V. De Smet, S.J." In: IDEM (ed.) – *New Perspectives on Advaita Vedanta: Essays in Commemoration of Professor Richard De Smet, SJ*. Leiden; Boston; Köln: Brill, 2000, p. 15 n. 29.

³⁷ Bernard LONERGAN – "Christology Today." In: *A Third Collection*, op.cit., pp. 74-99.

³⁸ Cf. e.g. Bernard LONERGAN – "Christ as Subject." In: *Collection. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 4, ed. F. E. Crowe and R. M. Doran. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988, pp. 162-166.

tend to ultimately downgrade not only ritual action and devotion but also, in the final analysis, the revealed word or *sruti*.³⁹ Here Lonergan would be one of the strongest advocates of the place of the kataphatic in religion, while making honorable place also for the apophatic. It seems to me that, common to the European Enlightenment, the clutch of philosophies deriving from it, modernist and liberal thought within Christian theology, and much of Indian thought, is an exaltation of the level of experience with the consequent neglect of the level of judgment.⁴⁰

2.5. Religion

An important area of study is Lonergan's new understanding of religion. Lonergan seems to have believed in a single overarching divine plan from at least 1935, and in chapter 20 of *Insight* he does speak about various possible divine solutions to the problem of evil. However, he came round to recognizing the universality of salvation and the place of the religions very clearly only in the post-conciliar period. Thus he speaks of religion in terms of the inner word of the gift of God's love given to all, and of "the religions of mankind in their positive moment, as the fruit of the gift of the Spirit."⁴¹ Such a position, together with his clear stand about the distinctiveness of Christianity and the right and duty to preach the gospel to all nations, makes him an interesting dialogue partner for Indian religions.

2.6. Social and economic issues

My own philosophical upbringing tends to make me focus on issues mainly within the Buddhist and Brahmanic currents of Indian thought. However, I would like to state here that Lonergan provides important resources for social critique and for economic theory. As far as social critique is concerned, there is, first of all, his key insight that dialectical method becomes applicable in any specifically human area. This merely means that, when dealing with any human phenomenon, we must expect truth as well as falsity, moral correctness as well as its opposite, good as well as evil. There is no culture in the

³⁹ Swami Abhishiktananda (the Benedictine monk Henri Le Saux) is reported to have been challenged by a Hindu *sannyasi* in Arunachala to give up celebrating the Eucharist and reciting the breviary: these were the only things, he said, that lay between him and the ultimate experience.

⁴⁰ Cf. Ivo COELHO – "Religious Experience and Expression in Lonergan," paper presented at the First International Lonergan Workshop, Pontifical Gregorian University, Rome, 7-11 May 2001 (unpublished).

⁴¹ Bernard LONERGAN – "The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World." In: *A Second Collection*. Philadelphia: Westminster, 1974, p. 174. Cf. Frederick CROWE – "Lonergan's Universalist View of Religion." In: M. VERTIN (ed.) – *Developing the Lonergan Legacy: Historical, Theoretical and Existential Themes*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004, pp. 111-141.

world, therefore, that can claim to be an unmixed and undiluted bag of goodness and truth. The study of Indian culture and society cannot, therefore, avoid using the dialectical method. Lonergan's further specification of dialectical method in terms of individual, group and general bias, the shorter and longer cycles of decline, etc. would be additional tools in the study of Indian culture and society. His insistence that method study concrete development – which means that the functional specialties history and dialectic, for example, have the task of inserting developments in ideas within the context of their concrete emergence – would have the salutary effect of forcing scholars to ask about the social and economic contexts within which what is called Indian thought arose. An analysis of the caste system in terms of group bias and general bias, and the consequences of such a system on the short and long term, would of course be quite interesting.

As for the area of economics, Lonergan's posthumously published work would naturally be quite interesting in its development of a 'third way' between savage capitalism and pure socialism.⁴² This third way is based mainly on two cardinal tenets of Lonergan's cognitional theory: that, just as insight is always into phantasm, so it is the concrete individual who alone can be intelligent in a given situation; and that, as any human situation calls for the use of dialectical method, there are no iron laws of economics that are immune to the influence of human decisions and choices. India, like China, seems to be in fact engaged in a massive historical experiment of combining the best of socialism with the advantages of capitalism, attempting to safeguard the weaker and historically disadvantaged sections of society while also giving free rein to the intelligence and enterprise of the man and woman on the spot. A thorough study of Lonergan's economics in the context of India might, therefore, be a welcome thing, and certainly more immediately feasible than the application of Lonergan's generalized empirical method to cultural and societal issues in India.

3. The Use of the Method for the Study of Indian Thought

Lonergan's mature thoughts on method are enshrined in a book entitled *Method in Theology*, and the theology to which reference is being made is mostly Christian theology. However, Lonergan himself admitted that the method could be used for the mediation of any cultural past to the present and the future. We can thus envisage the use especially of the first five functional specialties – research, interpretation, history, dialectic and foundations – for the study of Indian thought. Research would be a matter of gathering

⁴² Bernard Lonergan – *Macroeconomic Dynamics: An Essay in Circulation Analysis*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan vol. 15, ed. F. G. Lawrence, P. H. Byrne and C. C. Hefling. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1999; *For a New Political Economy*. Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 21, ed. P. J. McShane. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1998.

the data, producing critical texts and other critical apparatus; interpretation would be a matter of large numbers of scholars determining the meaning of these texts; history would be the task of further scholars putting together the various interpretations to determine the movements and developments of thought over time; dialectic would tackle the problem of conflicts within movements and also within the results of research, interpretation and history; foundations, finally, would involve objectification of the personal horizons of the interpreters to the extent possible, issuing in explicit stands on philosophical, moral and religious issues, on the basis of which positions could be taken on the conflicts dealt with in dialectic.

As will be evident, Lonergan's method is not brand new in all its parts. Vast amounts of research and interpretation are going on in the area of Indian thought. 'History' also, in Lonergan's specific sense of the term, is perhaps represented in the numerous histories of Indian philosophy that are available, though these would probably benefit from Lonergan's suggestion that interdependences and influences be sought and developments be identified (cf. his suggestion in *Insight* that genetic and dialectical sequences of viewpoints can be discovered in all human thinking). As for dialectic and foundations, these are also going on, but in what Lonergan would call a spontaneous and commonsense way, wherever there is mutual criticism and appreciation and the taking of personal positions. Lonergan's contribution is to make these spontaneous processes somewhat more deliberate and above all deliberately 'communitarian.' The functional special dialectic is designed to be done in a team, and so the method proposed by Lonergan is an explicitly dialogical tool. Dialectic, as I understand it, unfolds on three levels: a first level where it is applied by each individual investigator to the researches, interpretations and histories produced by other members of the team; a second level where it is applied to the results of the first level themselves; and a third level where the members of the team actually sit together for a personal encounter and dialogue.⁴³

The 'resonances' listed above are, in fact, best dealt with in the process of using Lonergan's method for the study of Indian thought. A sustained use of the method should, I believe, yield differently formulated but transculturally equivalent sets of philosophical and moral categories, which in turn could be used for the determination of similar sets of religious categories. Careful studies of the Christian as well as the Vedantic traditions could, I envisage, arrive at a commonly agreed upon usage of vexed terms such as creation, pantheism, panentheism, monism, acosmism, non-dualism, person. Much good work has already been done in this regard; the little attempt to illustrate the method at the end of the present article reveals, in fact, a startling and entirely

⁴³ IVO COELHO – *Hermeneutics and Method*, op.cit., pp. 184-187.

unexpected mutual influence and even convergence of views between Hindu and Christian scholars.

Increasing emergence of transculturally equivalent sets of categories would have the added benefit of providing the functional specialties with the type of explanatory upper blade called for towards the end of the chapter on interpretation in *Method in Theology*,⁴⁴ serving to get rid of 'occult' or inadequately methodical entities such as 'Indian mentality' and 'Western mentality.' For what is called Indian mentality may be just the manner that the religious pattern of consciousness differentiates itself from the everyday commonsense pattern to achieve the transcendent differentiation of consciousness in a significant number of individuals over time, and what is called the Western mentality may be just the fact that the theoretic differentiation of consciousness arose in a particularly significant manner in the bosom of the Western tradition, leading not merely to a systematic philosophy but also to the eventual emergence of empirical scientific method. Useful parallels may be found in what has been called the Hebrew mind or the Semitic mentality: here also we have the emergence of the transcendent differentiation of consciousness in a culture that did not achieve the theoretic differentiation, but remained for the most part in the undifferentiated consciousness of common sense. It is this non-differentiation of common sense that accounts for what is usually exalted as the holistic manner of thinking of the Hebrews, their ability to hold head and heart together, the way feeling penetrates all their thinking, etc. It is Lonergan's merit to have pointed out that these, far from being peculiar to the Hebrew mind, are a common characteristic of undifferentiated consciousness the world over. The Vedas and the Upanisads, for example, are clear instances of mystical experiences being expressed in the concrete, undifferentiated, holistic and symbolic language of common sense. Scriptures of all religions, precisely because they make use of commonsense symbolic language, speak to the whole human being, and not only to the head, as do the more esoteric theological treatises in each religion.

The method could of course be used in the efforts to create an Indian theology.⁴⁵ Since it is intrinsically dialogical, we could envisage not only Christian theologians studying the texts and realities of other religions, but also theologians and scholars of other religions forming part of the very method itself.⁴⁶ I have deliberately spoken not only of texts but also of the realities of other religions, for the method envisages that studies be done of religious interiority in

⁴⁴ Cf. MT, pp. 172-173.

⁴⁵ Ivo COELHO – "Applying Lonergan's Method: The Case of an Indian Theology." In: *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*. 22/1 (2004), pp. 1-22.

⁴⁶ Ibid., pp. 5-7.

its historical, phenomenological, psychological and sociological dimensions.⁴⁷ But I must add that the method can be seen as envisaging the study not only of the religious realities but also of the cultural, social and economic realities of the context in which theologizing is done.⁴⁸ Once again, however, we must acknowledge that much of this is already going on. What Lonergan brings is perhaps a measure of deliberateness to the ongoing process. His method, as he himself has said, is above all a framework for creative collaboration. It is not, he hastens to add, “a set of rules to be followed meticulously by a dolt”.⁴⁹ It demands, in fact, extraordinary doses of creativity and ingenuity if it is to be implemented fruitfully. As Fred Crowe has said, the tools for implementing Lonergan’s method are not yet existent.⁵⁰

At this point, I cannot resist asking what ‘stages of meaning’ might look like for India, but I will have to be content with some brief indications.

In common with all civilizations, there will be the commonsense or symbolic stage of meaning. Here we could place the high civilizations of the Indus valley which Lonergan deems ‘collectivist.’

Again, there is abundant data in India about the development of language.⁵¹ There is no dearth of alphabets, dictionaries, grammars and literary criticism in India, for there are the Sanskrit and Tamil alphabets, Panini, and sophisticated theories of art and literature. These are part of the reflex movement in which language comes to mediate and objectify and examine the linguistic process itself. The significance of this, says Lonergan, is the control it provides over mythic consciousness. Mythic consciousness lacks any clear dividing line between representation and perception, between wish and fulfillment, between image and thing, between dream and waking consciousness, between name and thing.⁵²

The development of language, together with the reflection occasioned by the disparities inherent in collectivist high civilizations, led to a more personal turn of thought, represented in India by early Jainism, the Brahmanism of the Vedas and the Upanisads, and early Buddhism. What emerged was the transcendent differentiation of consciousness.

⁴⁷ MT, p. 290. Cf. Bernard LONERGAN – “A Post-Hegelian Philosophy of Religion.” In: *A Third Collection*, op.cit., p. 217: “A special fruitfulness seems to reside in the study of ascetics and mystics.”

⁴⁸ Ivo COELHO – “Applying Lonergan’s Method”, art. cit., p. 9.

⁴⁹ MT, p. xi.

⁵⁰ Frederick CROWE – *The Lonergan Enterprise*. Cambridge, Mass.: Cowley Publications, 1980, p. 59.

⁵¹ MT, pp. 303-304: “The development... of symbols, of the arts, of a literature is intrinsic to human advance.”

⁵² MT, p. 92.

In the West, it was Parmenides who established linguistic argument as an independent power that could dare to challenge the evidence of the senses, thus making way for the distinction between sense and intellect.⁵³ In the East, or at least in India, it seems to me that the distinction between sense and intellect was initiated by Buddhism when it challenged the evidence of the senses and proposed a theory of *anatta*, the momentariness and impermanence of everything that seems stable to the senses. Buddhism in its turn influenced the Vedanta school of Hinduism which came up with a variety of explanations of the world in terms of appearance and illusion.

Was there an emergence of theory in the sense of a logical structure in which everything is interconnected and each term has a fixed meaning? I would not be as quick as Lonergan in discounting this possibility, for we have the various schools of Buddhism with their acute displays of logic and dialectic, as well as the schools of Brahmanism or Hinduism, one of which, the Nyaya, even specializes in logic. Again, we have a 'theological development' in Hinduism that quite parallels the Western Christian development, if we think of the Vedas, the Upanisads, the Bhagavadgita, the *sutras* and *karikas* (systematic collections of texts) of people like Badarayana, and the *bhasyas* or commentaries of people like Sankara, Ramanuja and Madhva. Whether any of these schools, or the treatises and commentaries they produced, really amount to theory in the sense outlined above, is a matter for further investigation and research. I note here merely that the split between the world of theory and the world of common sense is capable of several variations,⁵⁴ and that there are degrees in the achievement of theory.⁵⁵

Can we identify an emergence of the further distinction between understanding and judgment in India? I do not have the expertise to answer this question with competence. I content myself with the observation that Lonergan would probably regard this as an integral and important part of the theoretic differentiation of consciousness, as is evidenced by his repeated reference to the principle of contradiction and his observation that the stage of theory is marked by the emergence of the true as a specific goal.⁵⁶

⁵³ MT, pp. 91-92.

⁵⁴ Cf. MT, pp., 95-96. Cf. also INCW, p. 703, where Lonergan distinguishes a primary and a secondary process in the development of the positions, associating Pythagoras, Parmenides, Plato, Aristotle, Augustine and Aquinas with the former and the advance of mathematics and empirical science with the latter.

⁵⁵ Cf. MT, p. 84 "Classical consciousness is theoretical as well as common sense, but the theory is not sufficiently advanced for the sharp opposition between the two realms of meaning to be adequately grasped."

⁵⁶ In the first stage of meaning, the subject attends, understands and judges in pursuit of the concrete good; but he does not make a specialty of these activities. In the second stage of meaning, the subject continues to attend, understand and judge; but now he makes a specialty of these

Was there an emergence of an autonomous and empirical science in India as in the West? It does not seem likely, despite the claims of some today that most if not all the major scientific discoveries in the world were made in India. In Lonergan's understanding, the absence of this development should result in a certain weakness in the grasp of the theoretical differentiation of consciousness in India.⁵⁷

I would propose, then, that the development of consciousness in India displays at least the commonsense stage, the artistic and the literary differentiations of consciousness, the transcendent differentiation of consciousness, and the theoretical differentiation of consciousness. Such an outline could serve as an upper blade in the study of Indian thought. It would, for example, lend weight to the claim of Richard De Smet and others that Sankara, far from being a 'pure philosopher,' is clearly a *śrutivadin* or scripturally based theologian operating from within the transcendent differentiation of consciousness.⁵⁸ On the other hand, more work would have to be done to determine whether or not he operates from within the theoretical differentiation, or perhaps to determine the degree of theory that he had attained, for he is certainly more than familiar with the distinction between sense and intellect.

If, then, Lonergan's method can be used for the study of Indian thought, an outline of the development of consciousness in India, like the one I have attempted above, can provide an upper blade for that same study. Thus Lonergan's contribution to the study of Indian thought matches rather exactly his thinking on Indian culture, for the invariant structure of human consciousness is the basis of his method, while together with the variance in its unfolding it provides a theoretical anticipation in the study of the data.

4. Applying the Method: Some Pointers

As I have said already, the first five functional specialties of Lonergan's theological method could easily be applied to the study of Indian thought. Research would involve the production of a complete bibliography, e.g. on Sankara's understanding of the relation between *Brahman* and the world, covering the entire historical series of interpretations. Research would also

activities; he formulates a theoretical ideal in terms of knowledge, truth, reality, causality; he formulates linguistically a set of norms for the pursuit of that ideal goal; he initiates a distinct economic and social and cultural context within which that goal can be pursued. (Cf. MT, pp. 93-94.) "In the theoretical mode the good that is pursued is the truth... it is the specialization of attending, understanding, and judging." (MT, p. 94.)

⁵⁷ INCW, p. 703 and MT, p. 84.

⁵⁸ Radhakrishnan calls the Advaitism of Sankara "a great example of a purely philosophical scheme" (*Indian Philosophy*. Bombay: Blackie & Son, 1977, 2, p. 445. Cf. instead R. DE SMET – "Radhakrishnan's Interpretation of Sankara." In: *Radhakrishnan Centenary Volume*, ed. G. Parthasarathi and D. P. Chattopadhyaya. Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1989, p. 57.

involve the production of critical texts where necessary. Interpretation would involve the study of the texts listed in the bibliography, or at least an identification of existing studies and the study of the rest. History would involve putting together these interpretations to discover the developments over time. Dialectic would study the conflicts in the historical series as well as in the contemporary studies of that series. In foundations, finally, one takes a personal stand.

Obviously, one cannot wait until all critical texts are produced or all interpretations done. So one does what one can, whether by way of research or interpretation or history. Bibliographies, critical editions, translations, lexicons, grammars, dictionaries, all these can and are being produced. So also, there are plenty of efforts at interpretation, and these can be encouraged and added to. Again, history in Lonergan's sense could also be undertaken on the basis of whatever data is available, with the understanding that the results be subject to revision and completion. Finally, I would think that dialectic and foundations could also be undertaken on the basis of available data.

Lonergan's method involves team work, but individual and partial attempts are not to be excluded.⁵⁹ Again, the team should ideally be as diverse as possible, including people belonging to different religions and also agnostics and atheists, but then one has also to begin where one can.⁶⁰ Further, it would be important to have at least some members of the team who are familiar with the method, but the method itself is open to all comers, and familiarity with Lonergan is not a prerequisite. Since dialectic involves self-objectification, self-revelation as well as interpersonal encounter between members of the team, an *ashram* would provide the ideal setting with its atmosphere of prayerfulness, introspection and unhurriedness.⁶¹

Most of the specialties are being exercised in one way or another, as I have already pointed out. Lonergan's contribution is functional specialization, which brings a measure of order into this ongoing process, and among the specialties, dialectic and foundations have a key role. Lonergan has valuable suggestions to make in this regard. He suggests, for example, that we learn to distinguish different types of conflict: those that can be solved by an appeal to data; those that are merely genetic or else perspectival; and those that are dialectical, or radically opposed, so as to pose either-or options. He proposes that radical or dialectical conflicts are rooted in subjective factors, in the personal choices we make, deliberately or exercitively, in the areas of philosophy, morality and religion. Radical conflicts of interpretations are rooted in incommensurable horizons; they are rooted in different meanings of know-

⁵⁹ MT, pp. 137-138.

⁶⁰ Ivo COELHO – "Applying Lonergan's Method", art. cit., p. 6.

⁶¹ Ibid., p. 17.

ing, being, objectivity, value, ultimacy; they cannot therefore be resolved by mere arguments. Lonergan therefore proposes a method of self-revelation, a process that leads to the objectification of horizons. He recommends that this process be done in an atmosphere of mutual acceptance and cordiality, so that personal encounter might open ways that logical argument cannot.

I had intended to attempt a little exercise in dialectic at the end of this article, on the topic of Sankara's understanding of the relationship between *Brahman* and the world; constraints of time and space, unfortunately, made this impossible. The aborted attempt was itself, however, a great learning exercise. I discovered a startling agreement, pointing perhaps to a historical dependence, between Radhakrishnan, Mahadevan and Chatterjee-Datta.⁶² I found that, while they went out of their way to emphasize the relative reality of the world and its dependence on *Brahman*, they were reluctant to let go of the language of appearance and illusion. A Christian scholar like De Smet agreed that the world was relatively real and ontologically dependent on *Brahman*, but refused to regard it as appearance and illusion.⁶³ A Buddhist scholar like Sengaku Mayeda, on the other hand, had no hesitation in associating Sankara with the subjective idealism of the Buddhist *Vijnanavadins*.⁶⁴ On this point, he was in complete disagreement with Radhakrishnan, Mahadevan, Chatterjee-Datta as well as De Smet, who were of the opinion that Sankara had rejected the subjective idealism of the Buddhist *Vijnanavadins* and had upheld the reality of a world of objects existing independently of the human mind.

I also learned something about the method of dialectic. Lonergan speaks of dialectic as involving the eight steps of assembly, completion, comparison, reduction, classification, selection, distinguishing positions and counterpositions, developing positions and reversing counterpositions.⁶⁵ He is not,

⁶² S. RADHAKRISHNAN (ed.) – *History of Philosophy Eastern and Western*. London: George Allen & Unwin, 1952, vol. 1, ch. 13; S. RADHAKRISHNAN (tr. and intr.) – *The Brahma Sutra: The Philosophy of the Spiritual Life*. London: George Allen & Unwin, 1960; T. M. P. MAHADEVAN – *Sankaracharya*. New Delhi: National Book Trust of India, 1968; T. M. P. MAHADEVAN – *Invitation to Indian Philosophy*. New Delhi: Arnold-Heinemann, 1982, first published 1974; S. CHATTERJEE and D. DATTA – *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*. Calcutta: University of Calcutta, 1984, first published 1939.

⁶³ R. DE SMET – "Sankara's Non-Dualism (Advaita-Vada)." In: R. DE SMET and J. NEUNER (ed.) – *Religious Hinduism*. Allahabad: St Paul Publications, 1964, pp. 52-62; "Forward Steps in Sankara Research." In: *Darshana International*. 26/3 (1987), pp. 33-46; "Sankara's Non-Dualism (Advaita-Vada)." In: R. DE SMET and J. NEUNER (ed.) – *Religious Hinduism*. 4th ed. Mumbai: St. Paul, 1997, pp. 80-96; "Sankara Vedanta and Christian Theology." In: *Review of Darsana*. 1/1 (1980), pp. 33-48; "Radhakrishnan's Interpretation of Sankara." In: G. PARTHASARATHI and D. P. CHATTOPADHYAYA (ed.) – *Radhakrishnan Centenary Volume*. Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1989, pp. 53-70; "Radhakrishnan's Second Presentation of Sankara's Teaching." In: *Prajna*. 34 (1989), pp. 89-96.

⁶⁴ Sengaku MAYEDA – "Sankara and Buddhism." In: MALKOVSKY, op. cit., pp. 18-29.

⁶⁵ MT, p. 249.

however, very helpful about how each of these steps is to be carried out. My attempt at dialectic taught me that *assembly* and *completion* could be done together. Completion, in Lonergan's peculiar sense, involves the addition of evaluative interpretation and history, picking out the good things and their opposites.⁶⁶ This is what we usually do when we write articles and reviews, but Lonergan has a slightly technical suggestion to make: "To determine the legitimacy of any development calls for evaluational history; one has to ask whether or not the process was under the guidance of intellectual, moral, and religious conversion."⁶⁷ I learnt that, if completion is taken seriously, if one deliberately asks about the presence or absence of the conversions already at this stage, the steps that follow become much simpler, for they are a question of identifying radical oppositions, dismissing those that are not radical, and distinguishing positions and counterpositions. The most difficult part, however, is the last step, developing positions and reversing counterpositions. How does one do this? I found myself having to go back to the texts of Lonergan for greater clarity, and this had the effect of forcing me to revise my exercise in completion. The meaning of one of Lonergan's statements became luminous: to engage in dialectic is to provide others with evidence about one's own achievement or failure to achieve intellectual, moral and religious conversion.⁶⁸

Finally, my attempt at dialectic strengthened my conviction about the congeniality of Lonergan's method to the study of Indian thought, for there is a deep resonance between Lonergan's insistence on authenticity and the Indian tradition. Like the Indian tradition, Lonergan insists on the importance of authenticity for the intellectual endeavour. His method is built, in fact, upon the conviction that authenticity is a prized human possession, and that it will bear fruits in its own good time. In the course of my attempt at dialectic, I found examples of truly irenic dialectic in De Smet's engagement with Radhakrishnan.⁶⁹ I came across examples of great humility in dialogue such as Mahadevan's declaration at a seminar in the 1970's that "if the *Brahman* of Sankara is anything, it is surely not impersonal."⁷⁰ I had not expected to find Radhakrishnan and others insisting so clearly on the relative

⁶⁶ MT, p. 250.

⁶⁷ MT, p. 302. Cf. also MT, p. 312: "there can be many kinds of developments... to know them, one has to study and analyze concrete historical processes while, to know their legitimacy, one has to turn to evaluational history and assign them their place in the dialectic of the presence and absence of intellectual, moral, and religious conversion."

⁶⁸ MT, p. 253.

⁶⁹ DE SMET – "Radhakrishnan's Interpretation of Sankara"; "Radhakrishnan's Second Presentation of Sankara's Teaching."

⁷⁰ DE SMET – "Towards an Indian View of the Person," p. 51. Relying on the recent understanding of 'person' that began with Hegel rather than on the traditional Christian meaning that began with Boethius, Indian scholars usually regard the idea of person as applicable only

reality of the world, and found myself wondering whether this also was not the slowly maturing fruit of an ongoing dialectic and dialogue, as well as of the greatness and graciousness of men like Radhakrishnan.⁷¹ There are grounds, therefore, to believe that Lonergan's method, with its insistence on personal authenticity in all its dimensions, will find fertile ground in an Indian tradition that regards the intellectual and moral endeavour as preconditions of the spiritual search.

to the lower or *saguna Brahman* and not to the Absolute or *nirguna Brahman*. Cf. DE SMET – "Radhakrishnan's Interpretation of Sankara", pp. 65-66.

⁷¹ De Smet speaks of Fr. J. F. PESSEIN – *Vedanta Vindicated* (1925) as an endeavour that drew the admiration and large approval of eminent scholars like Radhakrishnan and S. Vedanta Aiyengar: cf. "Samkara Vedanta and Christian Theology," p. 37.